# SharePoint Security, Access Controls and Document Governance

Investigating information access risks, protecting controlled documents and establishing sustainable oversight

Family Solutions, Operations Manager

## Executive overview

At Family Solutions, a concern about an employee retaining access to leadership documents after a change in position led me to investigate how SharePoint permissions and documents were being managed. The review revealed a much broader problem: documents could be shared beyond their intended audience, approved forms were being overwritten, and employees could encounter outdated versions of policies and agreements.

I led a systematic cleanup of the SharePoint environment, using PowerShell to inventory files and identify duplicates, reviewing group and individual permissions, securing forms and sensitive content, and establishing document publishing and archive controls. I also developed recurring IT compliance reviews to help ensure access remained appropriate when employees changed roles or left the organization. The work improved control over organizational information while keeping current documents available to the employees who needed them.

## Identifying the underlying risks

The initial concern involved an employee whose role had changed but could still access prior role materials. As I reviewed the site, I found that employees with legitimate access could share files with others who did not need them, sometimes inadvertently granting editing rights as well as viewing rights.

I also uncovered a more serious issue with client intake packets. Staff were saving completed packets containing protected health information over blank templates in a program forms folder that was widely accessible to staff with program-level permissions. In a separate area, staff responsible for foster parent certification were retrieving outdated policies and agreements from familiar folders. Multiple versions of other documents appeared in searches, increasing the chance that employees would use an older version instead of the current approved one.

## Building a document inventory and restricted archive

I wrote a PowerShell script to export SharePoint document information into a consolidated CSV file. That inventory made it easier to identify duplicate records, locate conflicting versions and determine which documents needed to be retained as active resources. I reviewed the files and moved outdated or duplicate materials out of ordinary employee search and access paths.

I established a dedicated archive that only three designated governance personnel could search or access. This preserved historical documentation while reducing the likelihood that employees would retrieve superseded materials for current work. The archive also created a defined location and responsibility for handling future document retirements.

## Securing document access and protecting source files

I restored affected intake forms to blank versions and changed the permissions on controlled documents so employees could read and download the files they needed without editing or overwriting the SharePoint originals. I removed ordinary document-sharing and editing capabilities within SharePoint. Employees could download a document to work on a separate copy, but they could no longer alter the controlled source file through routine use.

I then audited SharePoint groups, group settings and access permissions. The PowerShell information I could retrieve supported group-level review, but it did not provide a complete list of individual user access. I used the automated information to remove inappropriate group permissions, then reviewed and corrected individual access manually. This combination of scripting and direct inspection allowed me to complete the permissions review with the tools available.

## Establishing document ownership and version control

I set publishing responsibilities according to the type of document. Department leaders could manage forms for their own teams. Organization-wide forms requiring broad access were coordinated through IT. Policies followed a more restricted approval process: staff submitted proposed changes to me, the Board reviewed changes before adoption, and only the Quality Systems Director or I published approved policies to SharePoint and Relias.

I also improved how employees located frequently updated forms. For example, the current mileage reimbursement form had a dedicated SharePoint tile so staff could find the approved version when the reimbursement rate changed. When forms were updated, I notified employees and asked them to remove superseded copies from their OneDrive folders. These changes kept the active SharePoint source authoritative while allowing employees to prepare and share proposed revisions outside the controlled library.

Some departments relied on established intake-packet folders that contained copies of policies. I tested linking those copies to the current policy, but the links were not reliable when document titles changed. I assigned the Quality Systems Director responsibility for verifying that policy copies in intake folders remained current and was exploring a more automated approach to that remaining maintenance task.

## Making access reviews part of ongoing IT compliance

To keep permissions accurate over time, I made SharePoint access review part of a quarterly IT compliance checklist. Employee access was blocked when employment ended, and the checklist verified that the remaining offboarding steps were completed. IT also reviewed permissions for access that no longer matched an employee's role or responsibilities.

I established a safeguard around license removal: an employee's license could not be removed until the complete offboarding checklist had been finished, reducing the risk of losing organizational data before it had been retained or transferred appropriately. The quarterly review provided a second opportunity to catch incomplete offboarding tasks and confirm that access controls remained current.

## Results and business impact

The SharePoint remediation addressed the exposed intake-template issue, and I did not encounter further incidents of completed PHI-containing packets overwriting the shared blank forms after the new controls were introduced. The permissions review corrected access that employees no longer needed, while restricted editing and sharing protected approved source documents from unintended changes.

The document inventory, controlled archive, assigned publishing rights and quarterly IT reviews created a more consistent approach to information governance. Staff could find current forms more easily, governance personnel had clearer responsibilities, and security checks became part of an established process rather than relying on a problem being reported. This project reflects my approach to operational risk: investigate the initial concern, identify the conditions that allowed it to happen, correct the immediate issue and put practical controls in place to reduce recurrence.